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Search begins for new UC president

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(*#_Company_Name_#*) BERKELEY, Calif. -- A special University of California Regents committee was created last Friday to search for a new UC President.

The committee's formation comes nearly two weeks after UC President Richard Atkinson announced his resignation. He will officially step down in October 2003.

The nine-member committee includes President of the Board of Regents Gray Davis and Student Regent Dexter Ligot-Gordon.

The search committee will select candidates for the position, and then the entire UC Board of Regents will vote on the new president.

Criteria for choosing the new president will be established by the committee in January, said UC spokesperson Michael Reese.

"As a committee, they need to consult with faculty, staff, students and alumni," Reese said. "And then they need to meet as a whole board to make a determination."

Reese said the board is "looking for someone with a vision of leadership and scholarship to maintain UC's quality and accessibility."

Ligot-Gordon, also a UC Berkeley student, emphasized the gravity of the task facing the committee.

"The selection of the president is one of the most, if not the most, important decisions of the (UC) Board of Regents," Ligot-Gordon said. "He executes the will of the board, and he can set the priorities for his own office, so he has a lot of power in the university."

UC Berkeley students said they hope the new UC President will pay more attention to student needs.

"I really hope the leader we pick remembers the primary function of the university system is to educate the students," said ASUC President Jesse Gabriel.

ASUC External Affairs Vice President Jimmy Bryant echoed these sentiments, adding the new president must know how to listen to students.

"I would hope they would choose someone who is well-rounded, someone open to students and staff of the university," Bryant said. "This is about creating better citizens, enlightening people (about) who we are and continuing the advancement of California."

Bryant said the president should seek students' opinions by personally interacting with them, even doing more interviews with student publications.

"I think it's just as important for that president to be as active as possible," Bryant added.

Ligot-Gordon said students are the "ultimate stakeholders of any decision the university makes" and that it is important for students to understand the administration and its actions.

"I think that students should be more involved, understand the people and processes that shape the campus environment," Ligot-Gordon said.

Other UC Berkeley students said the committee should select a president who understands campus issues.

"I would like to see someone with the capacity to understand the difficulties on campus because there are problems -- someone who's able to make decisions to benefit all the students," said UC Berkeley junior Bianca Moran.

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